

Personal Space

T.S

Fleur watched the dirt hills of the countryside speed past her, one leg resting out on the yellow guard rail. She had no idea where she was, no idea where she was going.

Just the way she liked it on a sunny afternoon.

Which station would she get off at? Would it be a booming metropolis, or an empty, barren village? Both would be exciting.

Seeing parts of her country, her world, that she would never visit in her regular life thrilled Fleur.

It helped distract her from the labours that plagued her.

The monotonous cage of her work. The fact that her parents still hadn't met her partner, that they knew the two of them were more than serious, and that they didn't know that Sam could be both a boy and a girl's name ...

"Hi there, how are you?" A voice made her look up.

A tall, young man with blonde hair smiled at her. He had a pretty face, long lashes curling over brown eyes.

Fleur eyed his buttoned polo and chinos with distaste and turned to continue looking out the window.

"Sorry, I don't mean to disturb you, it's just a long ride to my stop, and I always prefer having a chat to kill some time.

And talking with pretty people make the minutes *fly* by."

The compliment made her smile. She liked talking to strangers as well.

But the dinner was tomorrow night. There was so much pressure. Her dad had mentioned how excited he was to show Sam the BBQ and share a beer with what could be his future son-in-law ...

Fleur shook her head.

"Thanks. You seem really nice, but honestly I would rather be left alone right now."

"Oh come on, it's just a talk, it won't hurt anyone will it."

Instantly Fleur put her guard up, voice turning cold.

"I said I'm not interested, go away."

The man placed one hand on the yellow guard rail. Fleur withdrew her foot in response, shrinking underneath his looming presence. It seemed that the man grew in her vision, shadow deepening in the sun's rays.

"I don't care. We're both good-looking people, don't you want to have some fun?"

His voice was silk. Yet it provoked no desire. Fleur shifted to the side and jumped up, retreating a metre's length down the aisle. She clutched her handbag fiercely, one hand concealed inside.

"I've got pepper spray. Leave me the fuck alone ok?"

The man smiled and held his hands up.

"Alright, alright, sorry, can't blame a guy for trying. I'll let you be." He chuckled, tongue protruding out the corner of his mouth.

Fleur backed away, noticing with disgust that the only other two passengers were deliberately looking away.

Once she had moved down one carriage, she turned around and speedwalked another two. Finally, she sat down, pulling her hand out of her bag. It was shaking.

Rage filled her. How dare he ruin her afternoon? She should have threatened to call the cops, slapped his stupid face ...

Different fantasises whirled through her mind. It was so upsetting. No matter how much she tried to think of something else, her mind went straight back to their confrontation.

It was so unfair. She wasn't even mean to him, he just had to make it weird, and now she had to deal with the emotion that came with it. Not to mention the feelings she was

struggling to ignore. That small pit of fear, of what if he hadn't backed off ...

The train stopped at the next station. Fleur wasn't interested in heading to a random station anymore. Her body was teeming with anxiety, she wanted to go back to the city, to somewhere she knew, somewhere she *felt* comfortable.

The train began moving. She took a few deep breaths, trying to calm herself down.

It worked.

A minute later she stepped out onto the platform, sighing with relief as she looked up and down the train, no-one else had gotten off. Fleur walked to the underpass and crossed to the other side of the station. She stepped on the yellow bumpy strip on the black tarmac, looking down at the brown train tracks, before finding a seat and opening her diary.

She began sketching.

A black screaming face etched itself on the page, a cathartic release of the mania that still filled her. Once she had finished she sighed. It had been a while since she had drawn something wretched. With a smile on her face, Fleur began the pages. Seeing her diagrams of red lips, of manicured fingers, her shabby attempt of a rose and lily garden.

Ever since she had met Sam she had felt safe. Sam understood her like no-one else. Not to mention how gorgeous she was.

Every time Fleur thought about Sam, her heart would expand and warm her chest.

Her family wouldn't do anything to ruin that right?

Then why hadn't she told them yet? About who she was, how she felt? It wasn't like they were religious or anything.

She just ... she just ... she didn't want to face them. They almost certainly wouldn't care.

What scared her, what lay in that black pit in the corner of her brain that she didn't dare look down.

Was a simple question. What if they did?

Fleur closed her diary as a train arrived and stepped onto the carriage. She found a seat and put her headphones on, letting the smooth beat wash her feelings away. After a few stations, more people got on, until all the seats were filled, some commuters even standing.

The sun was starting to set as well, it was time to go home, to face what plagued her head on.

Tomorrow would be alright. And if it wasn't ... she had Sam by her side. They could withstand anything.

With a smile Fleur looked up and froze.

The man was standing down the carriage hallway.

And he was staring at her.

When he realised that she had noticed, he locked his eyes onto hers, smiling widely.

There were a few people in front of them, enough that Fleur felt safe. But her skin was crawling, every time she stole a glance she saw that he hadn't taken her eyes off of her.

Eventually, she locked her gaze with him, his tongue lolling out when she refused to look away.

Fuck him. Who was this guy anyway? Just some boy, some worm in a polo.

Humanise him, he was just a contemptible man, trying to make her uncomfortable for what? To get back at her for rejecting him? Thinking that this was the way to get into her pants?

She smiled at him; she wouldn't let him get to her.

With pleasure she watched, the man looked away, embarrassed.

He stepped to the edge of the train next to the carriage wall, looked back at her and made her shudder in revulsion.

The man began *licking* the train wall.

A pink tongue ran the length of the grimy surface, leaving a trail of saliva on the murk, eyes locked on hers the entire time.

The man winked, keeping his tongue dangling in the air.

Fleur sat paralysed as the train stopped at her station. Noone had noticed. Trembling she moved through the people to get off at the other end. With terror she saw that he had also stepped off.

He was following her.

With increasing urgency she made her way through the crowd, eyes hurting as the bright lights of the station flashed. She reached the barricades and looked backwards. He was striding towards her.

He somehow had space in the sea of commuters, parting them, as if each one who went near hit an invisible barrier and redirected themselves.

Fleur tapped her card on the reader, her hand was shaking, she dropped her card, and the reader buzzed with a red X. She crouched down, her bag almost falling off of her shoulder as she struggled to pick up the card, nails failing to get under it. Finally, she lifted the card and slammed it onto the reader, storming through the barricade when it opened. She took the escalator steps two at a time, refusing to look back, breath beginning to pant as sweat creased her

forehead. When she reached the top she burst out of the station, cold air slamming into her the face.

It was dark now, city skyscrapers enveloping the busy street with light. She took a step forward, terrible fear strangling her.

When she stopped.

What the hell was she doing?

She was stronger than this. Running away from some ... boy. Not man. Boy.

She wouldn't let him manipulate her like this. Fleur took a couple deep breaths, calming herself down.

When she felt relaxed, she began moving.

"Hello again."

His voice was a whisper, lips centre metres away from her ear. It took every bit of willpower for her not to scream as his pink tongue wriggled on the corner of her vision.

She took a step and turned around. He was leaning forward, both arms tucked behind his back as his eyes danced at her.

They were surrounded by people yet they also felt enclosed together, paradoxically alone. Neither of them said anything, just stared into each other's eyes. It made Fleur's fear begin to transform into something hot and fiery.

"If you don't leave me alone, I'll start screaming."

"Then try."

Fleur opened her mouth and unleashed the loudest squeal of her life.

No noise came out.

"What happened? Cat got your tongue?" He stroked one manicured finger on her chin as she tried to turn away. It felt like she was moving through thick sludge, she barely managed to twist her neck let alone move away.

"You my girl are mine and mine alone. It would have been easier if you had just succumbed to my will.

But only for you. I myself much prefer those that are hard to ... break."

Fleur stared in horror at his eyes, there were turning golden, illuminating light. She needed to move, to move, to MOVE.

With a cry she fell back onto her behind, shuffling backwards. She raised one hand to her throat and snarled.

"Fuck you."

She jumped up and ran, leaving him behind in the crowd.

Her heart was pounding, blood rushing as sprinted with no aim in sight. Despite the distance, she heard his sanguine voice, almost as if it was in the back of ear.

"Oh yes, I do so love a chase."

The End.